This early classical Tamil literature is a boon to historians because of what its tells us about Tamil society before Arya or Brahminical influence had penetrated the South. Even before the *Puranānuru* had been tracked down, transcribed and published by U. V. Swaminatha Iyer in the 1890s, Robert Caldwell was able to able to enthuse about how much information they revealed:

> They had ‘kings’, who dwelt in ‘strong houses’ and ruled over small ‘districts of country’ … They were well acquainted with ‘agriculture’ and delighted in ‘war’. All the ordinary or necessary arts of life, including ‘spinning’, ‘weaving’, and ‘dyeing’ existed among them. They excelled in ‘pottery’ … They had ‘minstrels’ who recited ‘songs’ at ‘festivals’ and they seem to have had alphabetic ‘characters’ written with a style [stylus] on Palmyra leaves. They were without hereditary priests and idols, and appear to have had no idea of heaven or hell, of the soul or sin, but they acknowledged the existence of God, whom they styled *ko*, or ‘king’ – a realistic title little known to Hinduism. They erected to his honour a temple, which they called *ko-il* [usually written *kovil*], ‘God’s house’; but I cannot find any trace of orthodoxy in the nature of the worship which they offered to him.[20]

As Caldwell also noted, this poetry was written as well as spoken, which brings us to another crucial innovation that can be credited to one or other or even both of the heterodoxies.

From the *Rig-Veda* onwards, the entire canon of Vedic and Brahminical ‘literature’ was preserved by memory alone. These were spoken texts, handed down by direct transmission from one initiate to the next, from *guru* (teacher) to *chela* (pupil). By this means what was contained within these spoken texts remained hermetically